

# Notes of International Politics

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International Politics

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## Part I

# Session 2

### Session 2, February 16: Grand theories of war and peace

\*\*\* (Bueno de Mesquita, 2013)[Chapter 5]

- (Levy, n.d.)
- (Lake, 2011)
- (Lake et al., 2021)
- (Milner et al., 2023)
- (Snyder, 2004)

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# 1 Bueno de Mesquita, 2013 Chapter 5

- War is generally inefficient compared to reaching a negotiated settlement.
- The risks of war may be exacerbated by uncertainty, making credible commitments, or winner-takes-all situation.
- Some important neorealist hypotheses about international peace and stability do not flow logically from that theory's core assumptions. Other important neorealist hypotheses are falsified by the empirical record.
- The link between power transition theory's assumptions and hypotheses is more clear-cut than is true in the case of neorealism.
- Some core power transition hypotheses follow from the theory's logic and are supported by evidence; others either do not follow logically or are not borne out by evidence.
- The power transition theory outperforms neorealism when it comes to offering a structural explanation for war, but its weaknesses point to a need to reconsider its approach to domestic politics.

Consider that estimates of war-related deaths per year in the past 100 years vary approximately from 1 to 2 million.

## 1.1 War and Uncertainty

The ex ante problems that seem to lead to war can be reduced to three main factors: (1) uncertainty, (2) commitment problems, and (3) indivisibility of issues (Fearon 1995; Slantchev 2003).

1 Absence of **credible commitments** between the sides.

1.1 The inability to **commit to negotiating** patiently rather than seizing the first-strike advantage exacerbates the risk of war (Powell 1999; Slantchev 2003)

1.2 The idea is that the Israelis give up some land in exchange for a guarantee of peace. An alternative formulation reverses the sequence of concessions—the Palestinian Authority disarms its factions that engage in violence against Israel in return for land concessions. Either approach is likely to fail because each induces a fundamental commitment problem.

**Land for peace** suffers from a time inconsistency problem.

2 Dispute is about an **indivisible objective** → No settlement can produce a compromise in this case of indivisibility, and so there is a severe risk of war. If control over all the land currently held by Israel is truly its irreducible objective, then the land is viewed as indivisible by Hamas.

3 This **uncertainty about the true probability of victory** or defeat might arise out of private (secret) information about the morale of their fighting forces, about knowledge of outside help, about the quality of their war plans, or a host of other possible factors.

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## 1.2 Realist Theory

Neorealist theorists believe that the distribution of power in the international system is a major factor in determining whether international affairs are stable or unstable. Stability refers to circumstances in which the sovereignty of key states is preserved (Gulick 1955). Instability refers to changes in the composition of the international system, especially changes involving the disappearance or emergence of “key” states following large wars. Key states are those whose assistance might be necessary to counteract a threat from a rival coalition of states.

In addressing war and instability, neorealist theories start with the following four assumptions:

1. International politics is anarchic.  $\Rightarrow$  there is no supranational authority that can enforce agreements between states.
2. States, as rational unitary entities, are the central actors in international politics.  $\Rightarrow$  domestic politics does not influence international politics.
3. States seek to maximize their security above all else and consider other factors only after security is assured.  $\Rightarrow$  states are not willing to trade away their security for other benefits. Other possible goals, such as wealth, are pursued only after security has been assured (Waltz 1979, 126).
4. States seek to increase their power as long as doing so does not place their security at risk.  $\Rightarrow$  states accept being weaker than they might otherwise be if the pursuit of greater power would place their security at risk.

Most important neorealist conclusions

1. Bipolar systems are more stable than multipolar systems.
2. States engage in balancing behavior so that power becomes more or less equally divided among states over time.
3. States mimic, or echo, one another's behavior.

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## 2 How Well Does Neorealism Do in Explaining War and Instability? Bipolar vs. Multipolar Systems

### Bipolar system

- Dominated by **two major powers**.
- Alliances and commitments are clearer.
- Neorealists argue that it creates **less uncertainty** and therefore **more stability**.

Bipolarity is thought to alleviate two of the conditions we have discussed that are thought to increase the risk of war: uncertainty and commitment problems.

### Multipolar system

- Contains **more than two major powers**.
- Alliances and third-party reactions are harder to predict.
- Traditionally associated with **greater uncertainty** and instability.

#### 2.0.1 Historical Examples and Justification for Neorealism

##### World War I

- Multipolar Europe had several major powers.
- Alliances and commitments were uncertain.
- Britain's and Italy's behavior was not fully predictable.
- This uncertainty supposedly contributed to instability.

##### Cold War

- Two clear blocs:
  - **US/NATO**
  - **USSR/Warsaw Pact**
- Commitments were much clearer.
- Used as evidence that bipolar systems involve less uncertainty.

#### 2.0.2 Problem with the Uncertainty Argument

The fact that multipolarity creates more uncertainty does **not automatically mean** that it creates instability.

Uncertainty may:

- make states more **cautious**;



- 
- make some states more **risk-acceptant**;
  - have different effects depending on decision makers.

Deutsch and Singer even argue that:

**multipolarity may be more stable precisely because it produces uncertainty.**

*Therefore : Uncertainty  $\nrightarrow$  Instability*

### 2.0.3 Problem for Neorealist Assumptions

The claim that bipolarity increases stability is **not logically derived from neorealism's basic assumptions**.

If leaders react differently to uncertainty:

- this conflicts with the **unitary rational actor assumption**;
- structural conditions would no longer produce similar state behavior;
- polarity would not have a predictable effect on stability.

### 2.0.4 Bipolar Balance of Power

**Implication:** Strict neorealist logic suggests that bipolar stability requires **near-perfect equality of power**.

In a multipolar system, stability depends on **blocking coalitions**.

A coalition controlling half the system's resources can prevent another coalition from becoming dominant.

Perhaps the most common claim among neorealist theorists is that war occurs only when both sides believe that their chance of winning is greater than 50 percent. This is a partial statement of what has come to be known as the balance-of-power theory. It invokes the idea that war is the product of mutual optimism by rival states, meaning that they overestimate their chances of victory

If the neorealist hypothesis were correct, we should observe no wars initiated by the weaker side. The evidence fails to support the hypothesis.

### 2.0.5 Essential vs. Inessential States

**Essential State** A state is essential if it is needed to form at least one:

- **blocking coalition**
- **winning coalition**

Other states have an incentive to protect it.

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**Inessential state** A state is inessential if coalitions can succeed without it.

Such a state becomes:

- expendable;
- vulnerable to elimination.

### 2.0.6 Example of a Stable Multipolar System

Even weak state E is essential to some blocking coalitions.

Therefore:

- other states have incentives to protect E;
- all states remain strategically relevant;
- the system can be **stable**.

### 2.0.7 Example of an Unstable Multipolar System

Coalitions can win without E.

Therefore:

- E is **inessential**;
- E can be eliminated without threatening the security of the others;
- the system is **unstable**.

### 2.0.8 Main Implication for Multipolarity

Multipolar systems can be stable under **many different distributions of power**.

Exact equality is not always required.

By contrast, bipolar systems may require a much more precise balance.

### Result

Neorealist assumptions may actually allow **more stable power distributions in multipolar systems than in bipolar systems**.

### 2.0.9 Historical Record of Essential and Inessential States

Inessential states are states that are unable to turn even one losing alliance into a winning or blocking coalition.

1. Essential states never become inessential.
2. Essential states are never eliminated from the international system.
3. Inessential states never become essential states.

- 
4. Inessential states are always eliminated from the international system.

Each of these propositions is historically false.

### 2.0.10 Bipolarity and Stability: War

A possible objection is that war is uncertain.

Even if one state is stronger, it may avoid attacking because victory is not guaranteed.

Let:

$$p = \text{probability of victory}$$

A attacks when:

$$p > U_{\text{status quo}}$$

assuming:

$$U_{\text{winning}} = 1, \quad U_{\text{losing}} = 0$$

War depends not only on power, but also on:

- expectations;
- risk;
- satisfaction with the status quo.

### Why This Contradicts Neorealism:

This model assumes states can make a:  $\Rightarrow$  **trade-off between security and power**

But according to Kenneth Waltz:  $\Rightarrow$  **security is the highest end.**

States seek power mainly as a **means to security**, not as an end in itself.

Allowing states to risk survival for possible gains in power therefore conflicts with core neorealist assumptions.

### 2.0.11 Overall Conclusion

The traditional claim: *Bipolarity*  $\rightarrow$  *Stability* has several problems:

- **uncertainty does not necessarily cause instability;**
- leaders may react differently to uncertainty;
- strict neorealist logic can make bipolar systems stable only under very narrow power distributions;
- multipolar systems can remain stable through **blocking coalitions**;
- introducing probabilistic risk-taking creates assumptions that contradict neorealism itself.

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## Central conclusion

**The hypothesis that bipolar systems are more stable than multipolar systems does not logically follow from neorealism's own assumptions.**

### 2.1 Bipolarity and Stability

1. First, variation in the response to uncertainty violates the unitary rational actor assumption, which contends that important choices in international politics are driven by structural factors, not by considerations internal to the state.
2. Second, if different decision makers respond to uncertainty in different ways, then there is no reason to expect any empirical relationship between bipolarity and stability at all.
3. Third, if leaders differ in how they respond to uncertainty, then the third hypothesis (that states mimic one another) does not hold up.
4. Starting from the neorealist assumptions, we can show that it is logically true that more distributions of power are stable in a multipolar world than in a bipolar world.

### 2.2 History and Neorealist Empirical Claims

1. The international system was multipolar in structure from 1648 until the defeat of Germany in 1945. Thus, between 1648 and 1945 there were many major powers with no one or two predominating.  $\Rightarrow$  The bipolar system began in 1945 and lasted until about 1989.
2. Using Jack Levy's (1983) classification of great powers since 1492, we can determine whether the longevity of the bipolar system was comparatively long or short.  $\Rightarrow$
3. Another way to evaluate the stability of the international system is to examine the frequency of wars among the most influential states in the world
4. The UN Security Council (UNSC), then, by institutionalizing a multipolar decision-making structure, has provided a counterweight to bipolarity. This too may be an explanation for the long peace.
5. The average interval between general wars is thirty-four years; the longest interval is ninety-nine years, much longer than the so-called long peace. It appears, then, that the bipolar, long peace cannot be considered unusually long after all and that bipolarity is not a superior treatment for the disease of major power war than is multipolarity.

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### 3 The Power Transition

Building on the work of Edward Carr (1939, 1945) and Organski (1958) constructed what was perhaps the first challenge to realism that was neither idealistic nor normative.

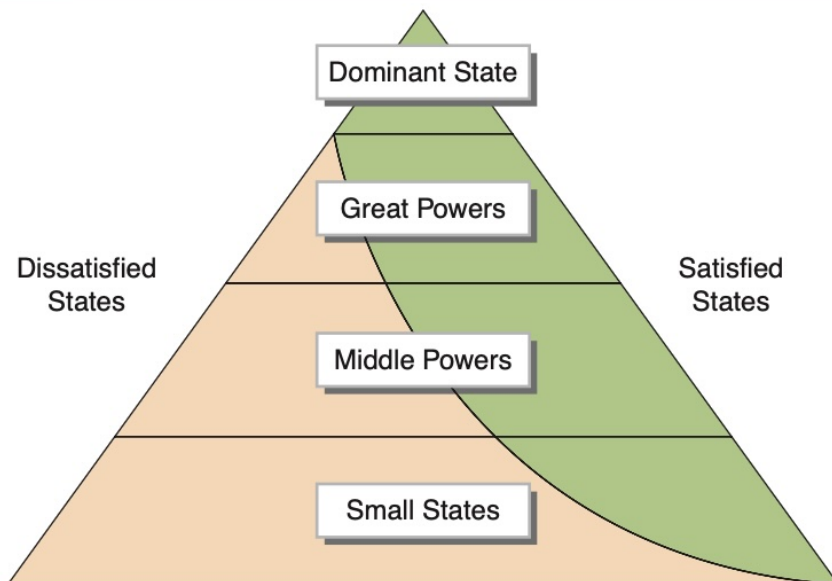
- The international system is not anarchic.
- There is only one dominant state at any given time.
- Rather than wishing to maximize security or power, nations are interested in maximizing their **control over the rules and customs that govern international interactions** so that they can define the status quo according to their interests.

Bretton Woods Agreement  $\Rightarrow$  These agreements still maintain a rule-based and normative influence on the trading practices of their members.

**Dissatisfaction**  $\Rightarrow$  it is the more powerful dissatisfied states that represent the biggest threat to international peace and stability.

**FIGURE 5.5**

**The Power Transition Power Triangle**



Power transition theory divides the world into two coalitions: (1) satisfied states and (2) dissatisfied states. The stronger a state is, the more likely that it is satisfied with the organization of the international system and the status quo that reflects that system's rules. Weaker states are more likely to be dissatisfied.

**Source:** Organski (1958).

Figura 1

#### 3.1 Dissatisfaction, the Status Quo, and War

Conflict arises when a dissatisfied state grows strong enough to challenge the authority of the hegemon. Because such a challenge concerns the very way in which international affairs are conducted, the ensuing conflict is fierce and costly.

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This time period during which the challenger roughly comes to equal and then surpass the dominant state in power is known as the power transition. It is the time when the threat of a major war is hypothesized to be at its peak. **Contrary to the balance-of-power perspective**, power transition and hegemonic stability theorists believe that major wars are most likely to occur when the power of the opposed states is about equal.

**According to these theorists, a balance of power promotes war.** They maintain that system-transforming wars—that is, wars that lead to a new power hierarchy and to new rules and norms—will occur only when the power of a challenger and the dominant state are about equal and the power of the challenger is increasing faster than that of the dominant state. These claims have been extended and shown to have **empirical strength** at the regional as well as the global level, so that regional hegemons apparently face the same pressures and the same sources of war as their global counterparts.

Threatening balance of power emerges as a result of differing rates of internal growth between a dominant state and a challenger state. These theories still give little attention to domestic politics per se, but they do recognize that internal factors shape rates of growth.

Power transition theory leads to the hypothesis that system-transforming, high-cost wars are especially likely when a dissatisfied challenger state achieves approximate power parity with the dominant, status quo-defending state.

Kim and Morrow have shown that the distribution of power at which the rivals will fight depends on their willingness to take the risks of waiting. The longer the challenger waits to attack, the higher is its probability of victory. This is true because the challenger's power is growing faster than the dominant state's power. Thus, the longer the challenger puts off a war, the greater will be the odds in its favor. However, the longer it waits, the longer it must endure the rules of international intercourse with which it is dissatisfied.

Kim and Morrow have shown that the interval during which the challenger is willing to fight expands as the expected costs of the war increase, as the challenger's dissatisfaction with the status quo increases, as the challenger's relative growth rate declines, and as the challenger becomes more risk acceptant.

How long the challenger and the dominant states will wait before fighting depends on their respective responses to risk, their relative rates of growth, the expected costs of the war, and their respective degrees of satisfaction with the status quo.

Differences in growth rates turn out not to be crucial empirically.

Power transitions per se cannot explain especially costly wars.

**FIGURE 5.6**

**Power Transition Theory and the Likelihood of War**

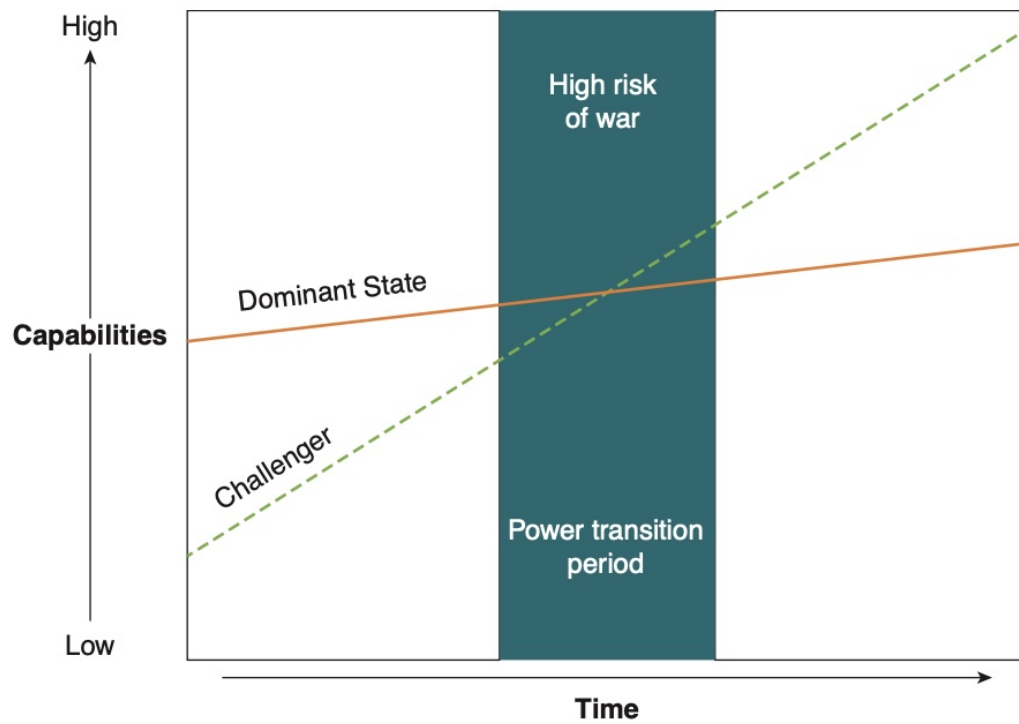


Figura 2

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## 4 Levy, n.d.

This makes it hard to argue that human nature and related factors are causes of war. The point is that these factors are constants and cannot explain the variations in war and peace over time and space (Waltz 1959, Cashman 1993).

Why does war occur at some times rather than other times, between some states rather than other states, under some political leaders rather than others, in some historical and cultural contexts rather than others, and so on? This differs from still a third question: How do we explain the origins of a particular war? Most international relations scholars (and particularly those in North America) focus primarily on the second question, explaining variations in war and peace. They leave the question of why war occurs at all to philosophers and biologists and leave the question of why a particular war occurs to historians.

Although **anarchy** may provide one persuasive answer to the question of the permissive causes of war, it is generally treated as a structural constant and consequently it cannot account for variations in war and peace.

### 4.1 The Levels-of-Analysis Framework

Waltz (1959) classified the causes of war in terms of their origins in the individual, the nation-state, and the international system  $\Rightarrow$  levels-of-analysis framework as an organizing device for the study of war.

In this sense the systemic level of analysis refers to explanations of patterns and outcomes in the international system; the dyadic level refers to explanations of the strategic interactions between two states; the national level refers to explanations of state foreign policy behavior; the organizational level refers to explanations of the behavior of organizations; and the individual level refers to explanations of the preferences, beliefs, or choices of individuals.

We cannot assume that correlations or causal connections at one level of analysis are necessarily valid at another level. It is conceivable, for example, that concentrations of power may promote peace at the dyadic level but war at the system level.

### 4.2 Systemic-Level Theories

The realist tradition has dominated the study of war since Thucydides and includes Machiavellians, Hobbesians, classical balance of power theorists, Waltzian neorealists, and hegemonic transition theorists. Although different realist theories often generate conflicting predictions, they share a core of common assumptions: the key actors in world politics are sovereign states that act rationally to advance their security, power, and wealth in a conflictual international system that lacks a legitimate governmental authority to regulate conflicts or enforce agreements.

- they use Prisoner's Dilemma and stag-hunt models
- The core proposition of realist theory is that the distribution of power, throughout the system or within a dyad, is the primary factor shaping international outcomes.

We should treat realism as a paradigm rather than as a theory, and focus instead on specific theories that generate more determinant, testable propositions.



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#### 4.2.1 Hegemonic Theory or Power Transition Theory

Hegemonic theory is a structural theory that incorporates power transition theory and hegemonic stability theory and that **downplays the importance of anarchy**.

Hegemons commonly arise and use their strength to create a set of political and economic structures and norms of behavior that enhance the stability of the system while advancing their own security. Differential rates of growth, the costs of imperial overextension, and the development of vested domestic interests lead to the rise and fall of hegemons, and the probability of a major war is greatest at the point when the declining leader is being overtaken by the rising challenger.

Power transition theorists disagree somewhat on the precise identity of hegemonic wars and the particular causal dynamics from which they arise.

#### 4.2.2 Balance of Power Theory

Balance of power theory is more concerned with explaining national strategies, the formation of blocking coalitions, the avoidance of hegemony, and the stability of the system than the origins of wars, which are underdetermined.

There is a major debate, however, between classical realists, who argue that stability is further supported by the presence of a multipolar distribution of power and a “flexible” alliance system (Morgenthau 1967, Gulick 1955), and neorealists, who argue that bipolarity is more stable than multipolarity (Waltz 1979, Mearsheimer 1990).

**Balance of power theory and power transition theory appear to be diametrically opposed**; the former argues that hegemony never occurs and that concentrations of power are destabilizing, and the latter argues the opposite.

#### 4.2.3 Realism and Liberalism

The relationship between economic interdependence and war is an old question that has attracted new attention in the past few years.

**Liberal economic theory of war:** Montesquieu [1777 (1748)] stated that “peace is the natural effect of trade,” and liberal economic theorists since Smith [1937 (1776)] and Ricardo [1777 (1817)] have argued that capitalist economic systems and the free exchange of goods in an international market economy are the best guarantors of peace.

**Realist:** they often argue that the effect of trade on war is small relative to that of military and diplomatic considerations. They also question the liberal assumption that trade is always more efficient than military coercion in expanding markets and investment opportunities and in promoting state wealth.

Whether the incentives for the gains from trade dominate the incentives for coercion or protection based on economic asymmetries, and whether the latter escalate to trade wars and militarized conflicts, are empirical questions that analysts have only recently begun to analyze systematically.

#### **Historical and empirical evidence of trade between enemies**

Although liberals and realists disagree on the effects of trade on war, **they appear to agree that trade and other forms of economic interchange between societies will cease or be drastically reduced once states are at war with each other**. Contrary to both liberal and realist expectations, however, **there are numerous historical cases of trade between enemies** during wartime, and a preliminary quantitative study suggests that war frequently

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does little to depress the volume of trade between adversaries (Barbieri & Levy 1997).

Need to incorporate domestic variables into their hypotheses

**States often hesitate to terminate trade with the enemy for fear that they will lose that trade to a third party**, who may be a greater economic or military rival.

These omissions have led all but the most committed neorealists to conclude that **systemic-level theories are theoretically incomplete and empirically inadequate**, in that **they leave too much of the variation in the outbreak and expansion of war unexplained**.

### 4.3 Social-Level Theories

Although interest in Marxist-Leninist theories has waned, there has been a tremendous growth of research on the relationships between regime type, particularly democratic regimes, and war (analyzed by Ray in this volume). Scholars have also devoted attention to the "diversionary" use of force for domestic political purposes, to the impact of ethnonationalism on international conflict, and to other domestic sources of international conflict.

"rally around the flag" effect (Mueller 1973).

This is the age-old "scapegoat hypothesis" or "diversionary theory of war" (Levy 1989a).

As Bodin argued, "the best way of preserving a state, and guaranteeing it against sedition, rebellion, and civil war is to...find an enemy against whom [the subjects] can make common cause" (quoted in Levy 1989a, p. 259).

research on the scapegoat hypothesis

The absence of significant findings regarding the relationship between internal and external conflict contrasts sharply with evidence of external scapegoating from historical and journalistic accounts and from a growing body of case-study evidence.

Most of these studies have focused on democratic regimes, partly because of the ease of measuring elite support levels but also because of the assumption that the greater political accountability of leaders in democratic states makes them more likely than authoritarian leaders to engage in external scapegoating.

These models help to explain "gambling for resurrection" through risky foreign policies by poor leaders who expect to be removed by their constituents (Downs & Rocke 1995).

This raises the question of how external actors perceive and respond to diversionary actions.

Marxist-Leninist models of imperialism, like models of scapegoating, implicitly assume that external expansion and the use of force serve the interests of the ruling class or elite but not those of society as a whole.

If the costs of aggressive foreign policies are too high—and we have enough examples of "imperial overstretch" to suggest that they sometimes are—it is not clear how elites maintain their power. As Snyder (1991) argued, groups concentrated enough to benefit from overexpansion are too narrow to control state policy, while those broad enough to control policy are too diffuse to reap benefits from overexpansionist policies.

For Snyder, this rationalist model of logrolling is not sufficient to explain overexpansion or the stability of the ruling coalition.

### 4.4 Individual-Level Theories

decision-making is characterized by "bounded rationality" **Assumptions:**

- 
- (a) that external and internal structures and social forces are not translated directly into foreign policy choices;
  - (b) that key decision-makers vary in their definitions of state interests, assessments of threats to those interests, and/or beliefs as to the optimum strategies to achieve those interests; and
  - (c) that differences in the content of actors' belief systems, in the psychological processes through which they acquire information and make judgments and decisions, and in their personalities and emotional states are important intervening variables in explaining observed variation in state behaviors with respect to issues of war and peace.

**Prospect Theory** one of the most recent attempts to apply a social-psychological model to international relations (Kahneman & Tversky (1979)).

Prospect theory assumes that people evaluate outcomes in terms of deviations from a reference point or aspiration level rather than in terms of net-asset levels.

This asymmetry of behavior with respect to gains and losses means that the way people frame their reference point in any given choice problem is critical.

#### 4.5 General Trends

- shift away from the systemic level: dissatisfaction with the failure of structural systemic models to explain enough of the variance in war and peace. This shift has led to rising interest in both dyadic-level behavior and societal-level explanatory variables.
- Whatever the relationship between concentrations of military and economic capabilities at the systemic level, there is substantial evidence that at the dyadic level an equality of capabilities is significantly more likely to lead to war.
- In the past decade most international relations theorists have moved beyond their earlier preoccupation with explanations at a single level of analysis and debates about which level provides the most powerful explanations. They now give much more attention to interaction effects among variables at different levels in the processes leading to war

## 5 One World Rival Theories

Snyder (2004)

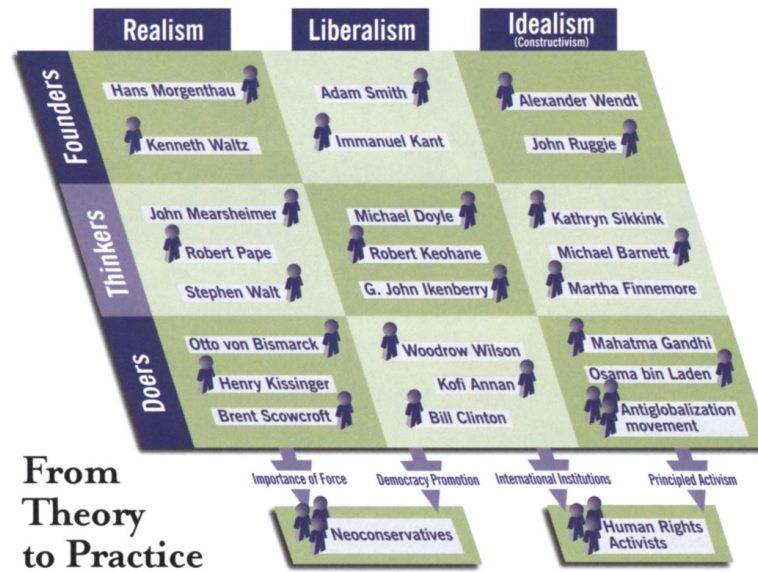


Figure 3

Realism instills a pragmatic appreciation of the role of power but also warns that states will suffer if they overreach. Liberalism highlights the cooperative potential of mature democracies, especially when working together through effective institutions, but it also notes democracies' tendency to crusade against tyrannies and the propensity of emerging democracies to collapse into violent ethnic turmoil.

Idealism stresses that a consensus on values must underpin any stable political order, yet it also recognizes that forging such a consensus often requires an ideological struggle with the potential for conflict.

It is harder for the normally state-centric realists to explain why the world's only superpower announced a war against al Qaeda, a nonstate terrorist organization. How can realist theory account for the importance of powerful and violent individuals in a world of states? Realists point out that the

Post-9/11 developments seem to undercut one of realism's core concepts: the balance of power.

When Germany unified in the late 19th century and became Europe's leading military and industrial power, Russia and France (and later, Britain) soon aligned to counter its power. Yet no combination of states or other powers can challenge the United States militarily, and no balancing coalition is imminent.

## 5.1 The Divided House of Liberalism

For its part, the Bush administration highlights democracy promotion while largely turning its back on the international institutions that most liberal theorists champion.

The belief that democracies never fight wars against each other is the closest thing we have to an iron law in social science.

Shortly before September 11, political scientist G. John Ikenberry studied attempts to establish international order by the victors of hegemonic struggles in 1815, 1919, 1945, and 1989. He argued that even the most powerful victor needed to gain the willing cooperation of the vanquished and other weak states by offering a mutually attractive bargain, codified in an international constitutional order.

## The Leading Brands

| Theories:                                                  | Realism                                                                                                                                                               | Liberalism                                                                                                                                                                       | Idealism<br>(Constructivism)                                                                                                                    |
|------------------------------------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Core Beliefs                                               | Self-interested states compete for power and security                                                                                                                 | Spread of democracy, global economic ties, and international organizations will strengthen peace                                                                                 | International politics is shaped by persuasive ideas, collective values, culture, and social identities                                         |
| Key Actors in International Relations                      | States, which behave similarly regardless of their type of government                                                                                                 | States, international institutions, and commercial interests                                                                                                                     | Promoters of new ideas, transnational activist networks, and nongovernmental organizations                                                      |
| Main Instruments                                           | Military power and state diplomacy                                                                                                                                    | International institutions and global commerce                                                                                                                                   | Ideas and values                                                                                                                                |
| Theory's Intellectual Blind Spots                          | Doesn't account for progress and change in international relations or understanding that legitimacy can be a source of military power                                 | Fails to understand that democratic regimes survive only if they safeguard military power and security; some liberals forget that transitions to democracy are sometimes violent | Does not explain which power structures and social conditions allow for changes in values                                                       |
| What the Theory Explains About the Post-9/11 World         | Why the United States responded aggressively to terrorist attacks; the inability of international institutions to restrain military superiority                       | Why spreading democracy has become such an integral part of current U.S. international security strategy                                                                         | The increasing role of polemics about values; the importance of transnational political networks (whether terrorists or human rights advocates) |
| What the Theory Fails to Explain About the Post-9/11 World | The failure of smaller powers to militarily balance the United States; the importance of non-state actors such as al Qaeda; the intense U.S. focus on democratization | Why the United States has failed to work with other democracies through international organizations                                                                              | Why human rights abuses continue, despite intense activism for humanitarian norms and efforts for international justice                         |

Figura 4

### 5.2 Idealism

Idealism: the belief that foreign policy is and should be guided by ethical and legal standards.

**Constructivism is a new version of idealism:** holds that social reality is created through debate about values, often echoes the themes that human rights and international justice activists sound.

Perhaps most important, Europe's increasingly legalistic approach to international relations, reflected in the process of forming the European Union out of a collection of sovereign states, provides fertile soil for idealist and constructivist conceptions of international politics.

**Whereas realists dwell on the balance of power and liberals on the power of international trade and democracy, constructivists believe that debates about ideas are the fundamental building blocks of international life. Individuals and groups become powerful if they can convince others to adopt their ideas.**

Realists failed to predict the end of the Cold War, for example. Even after it happened, they tended to assume that the new system would become multipolar.

Likewise, the liberal theory of democratic peace is stronger on what happens after states become democratic than in predicting the timing of democratic transitions, let alone prescribing how to make transitions happen peacefully.

Constructivists are good at describing changes in norms and ideas, but they are weak on the material and institutional circumstances necessary to support the emergence of consensus about new values and ideas.

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With such uncertain guidance from the theoretical realm, it is no wonder that policymakers, activists, and public commentators fall prey to simplistic or wishful thinking about how to effect change.

## **6 Why "isms" Are Evil David Lake**

Lake, 2011

### **6.1 Central Argument and Purpose**

Lake's essay is a critique of how international studies is organized intellectually and professionally. His central claim is not that theoretical diversity is undesirable, but that scholars have turned theoretical traditions and epistemological preferences into academic "sects." Instead of using theories as limited tools for understanding specific problems, researchers often treat broad traditions such as realism, liberalism, constructivism, Marxism, neoliberal institutionalism, feminism, or the English School as competing intellectual religions. Each group tends to defend its own assumptions, produce research that confirms those assumptions, and debate rival traditions at the level of first principles. In Lake's view, this sectarian organization generates less understanding rather than more. It also distracts scholars from their fundamental social responsibility: improving knowledge of world politics and, where possible, identifying ways to promote more humane outcomes.

The problem is especially serious because the discipline does not possess a single, universal and empirically powerful theory of international politics. World politics is too complex, and existing knowledge is too incomplete, for one general framework to explain everything. Lake therefore urges intellectual humility. Scholars should accept that most theories are partial and contingent, specify the conditions under which they apply, and concentrate on mid-level explanations of concrete phenomena. He favors "analytic eclecticism": researchers should be willing to draw on different assumptions and theories when different problems require different tools. At the epistemological level, he makes a parallel argument. The divide between nomological and narrative forms of explanation is real and enduring, but neither approach is universally superior. Both can produce valid knowledge, and the relevant question is which approach is most illuminating for a particular research problem.

### **6.2 Theory: How Research Traditions Become Academic Sects**

International studies has long been divided into what are often called paradigms, but Lake prefers the term "research traditions." Each tradition contains a set of core assumptions concerning the relevant actors in world politics, their interests, the processes through which they make decisions, and the nature of political interaction. Different traditions may focus on individuals, groups, states, or other collectivities; assume that actors seek wealth, power, security, status, identity, or justice; and portray international politics as fundamentally conflictual, cooperative, or socially constructed. These assumptions are useful because they simplify a complex reality and help researchers identify puzzles. The difficulty arises when scholars forget that they are simplifications and begin to treat them as complete theories or even as truths about the world.

Lake argues that the coexistence of many traditions should be expected. International politics is an exceptionally complicated social system, so it is unsurprising that different approaches illuminate different parts of it. The discipline's weakness lies not in pluralism itself but in the professional practices that transform pluralism into sectarianism. He identifies five linked pathologies.

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Together they encourage scholars to defend approaches rather than explain phenomena, reward intellectual extremism, and create self-confirming research communities.

### **6.3 The first pathology: reifying research traditions**

The first pathology is the reification of research traditions. Scholars routinely organize literature reviews, courses, graduate seminars, handbooks, and disciplinary histories around familiar “isms.” This has practical advantages because it provides a convenient map of a large literature, but it also creates artificial boundaries. Complex scholarship is reduced to a few recognizable schools, subtle differences within traditions disappear, and authors are classified according to labels they may not accept themselves. Scholars may see their own work as eclectic and nuanced while categorizing opponents as “realists,” “constructivists,” or “liberals.” As a result, intellectual identities are partly imposed by others. The discipline collectively produces the very categories that then appear to be natural and independent objects.

### **6.4 The second pathology: rewarding extremism**

Once research traditions are reified, the discipline rewards the clearest and most extreme statements of each tradition. Canonical works such as Waltz’s *Theory of International Politics*, Keohane’s *After Hegemony*, or Wendt’s *Social Theory of International Relations* become shorthand for entire approaches. In the process, qualifications and subtleties are often lost. These iconic texts gain visibility through citations and teaching, while younger scholars learn that professional recognition may come from taking a distinctive sectarian position. New “isms” and specialized sections of professional associations can also become vehicles for status and intellectual entrepreneurship. The result is a centrifugal process in which extremism generates more extremism, even if the original authors were more nuanced than later portrayals suggest.

### **6.5 The third pathology: confusing traditions with theories**

The third pathology is the tendency to mistake a research tradition for a complete theory. A tradition usually supplies broad assumptions, but those assumptions are rarely sufficient to generate unique, deductively valid predictions. Lake uses neorealism as an example. Waltz claimed that anarchy and the desire for survival imply balancing behavior, yet the same assumptions can also be compatible with cooperation, collective security, or bandwagoning unless additional assumptions are introduced. Similar indeterminacy appears in debates over relative versus absolute gains in neorealism and neoliberalism. This is why several distinct theories can coexist inside a single tradition—for example, offensive realism, defensive realism, and neoclassical realism. They share some core premises but differ in auxiliary assumptions. Because traditions are often underspecified, they cannot be meaningfully “tested” as wholes. Yet scholars frequently stage empirical contests between traditions as if each generated clear predictions, producing debates in which each side can interpret evidence as confirmation.

### **6.6 The fourth pathology: selective empirical focus**

The fourth pathology is empirical selectivity. Researchers tend to study the topics, periods, and cases in which their preferred tradition is most likely to perform well. Realists often focus on great-power security, liberals on economic policy, institutionalists on institutions, constructivists on norm change, and English School scholars on socialization and international society. This pattern need not result from deliberate bias; it can emerge naturally because scholars test theories where they initially expect them to work, while journals and publishers also favor positive findings.

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Nevertheless, the cumulative consequence is self-confirmation. Each tradition studies its strongest domain, finds supportive evidence, and then treats that evidence as proof of general explanatory power. The research tradition begins to function like theology: evidence is selected to affirm a prior commitment rather than used to subject theory to demanding attempts at falsification.

## **6.7 The fifth pathology: the search for intellectual hegemony**

The fifth pathology is the aspiration of each research tradition to become the dominant scientific paradigm. Scholars often identify themselves as realists, constructivists, or institutionalists in ways that imply their preferred approach is broadly superior to alternatives. Professional incentives reinforce this competition. If a tradition becomes dominant, its leading scholars gain status, influence, and control over disciplinary agendas. Because every group fears losing ground to its rivals, competition for hegemony resembles an arms race: even scholars who would prefer cooperation feel pressure to defend and expand their approach. The collective result is worse for everyone. Rather than acknowledging the limited scope of existing theories, research communities expend enormous energy debating assumptions such as whether actors are rational, whether structure or agency matters more, or whether power, wealth, norms, or identity should be treated as fundamental. Without comparable theories applied to the same phenomena, these “first-principle” debates cannot be decisively resolved.

## **6.8 Lake’s Alternative: Problems, Partial Theories, and a Common Lexicon**

Lake’s preferred alternative is to reorganize scholarship around substantive problems rather than around intellectual sects. Courses, conference sections, and research agendas could focus on issues such as war, climate change, development, inequality, genocide, or political violence. The guiding question would then be “What do we know about this problem?” rather than “What are the core assumptions of this school?” Such an organization would encourage scholars to compare explanations on the basis of their contribution to understanding a phenomenon instead of their loyalty to a tradition.

A central part of this alternative is what Lake calls an “embrace of partiality.” Theories should state their scope and boundary conditions explicitly and identify what they do not explain. A theory is not weakened merely because it applies only under certain conditions. On the contrary, clarity about limits improves scientific evaluation because scholars can distinguish genuine failures from cases outside a theory’s intended domain. Lake proposes that authors should routinely include a brief statement of boundary conditions and explanatory limitations. This would also make it easier to combine knowledge from different theories. His metaphor is the familiar image of several people touching different parts of an elephant: each theory may capture one part accurately, while no single theory describes the entire animal.

Lake explicitly rejects atheoretical research. Theories remain necessary for explaining patterns and identifying causes. His argument is instead that scholars should use theories flexibly. A researcher might employ a rational unitary-state model to study war, a theory of individual norms to investigate global environmental change, and a sectoral material-interest model to explain trade policy. Using different theories for different problems should not be treated as intellectual inconsistency if each theory is appropriate to the question at hand.

## **6.9 Interests, interactions, and institutions as a “Rosetta stone”**

Analytic eclecticism creates a possible communication problem: if scholars abandon fixed traditions, the field could become a “tower of Babel” in which theories are too different to



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compare. Lake therefore proposes a common lexicon built around three broad concepts: interests, interactions, and institutions. Any complete theory of politics must specify who the relevant actors are, what they want, how they interact, and the institutional environment in which interaction occurs. Actors may be individuals, groups, organizations, or states. Interests may involve power, wealth, identity, status, security, or normative goals. Interactions may involve zero-sum bargaining, cooperation, socialization, or the reproduction of inequality. Institutions may range from weak or epiphenomenal arrangements to dense structures that constitute actors and enable communication itself.

This lexicon is deliberately neutral among traditions. A rationalist theory may assume groups pursue material interests, while a constructivist theory may explain interests as socially constituted. A realist analysis may treat states as the principal actors, while another approach disaggregates states into domestic groups. Yet both can still be translated into the same basic questions about actors, interests, interactions, and institutions. Components can also be modular: something treated as given in one theory can be explained in another. Regime type, for example, may be used as an independent variable in a theory of war and then become the dependent variable in a separate theory of democratization. The goal is not theoretical unification, but clearer comparison, better specification, and cumulative knowledge.

## **6.10 Epistemology: The Enduring Divide**

Lake then turns from theory to epistemology. He identifies a deep divide between nomological and narrative forms of explanation. This cleavage has shaped major debates in international relations for decades and, in his view, is harder to bridge than differences among theoretical traditions. However, he does not believe that one epistemology will or should defeat the other. Both have long histories, both respond to different intellectual intuitions, and both can generate valuable knowledge. The discipline should therefore accept epistemological diversity rather than politicize it.

## **6.11 The nomological approach**

The nomological approach seeks generalizable explanations based on covering laws or theoretically specified relationships. It typically uses the hypothetical-deductive method: researchers derive falsifiable propositions of the form “if X, then Y” and test them using designs that approximate controlled experiments. True experiments offer the strongest internal validity, followed by quasi-experiments and then correlational studies such as regression analysis. Causal claims can emerge either from a strong design that isolates the effect of X on Y or from a combination of theory and robust empirical association. Lake notes that much international-relations research relies on the weaker correlational form. Science in this tradition is iterative: theory generates hypotheses, evidence tests them, and theories are revised, extended, or occasionally rejected.

For Lake, generalizability in nomological research depends primarily on theory rather than on the particular sample used in a test. If a theory is explicitly intended to apply to all humans, evidence from a narrower sample can still be relevant provided the test has strong internal validity. Conversely, findings from a particular population cannot validate a theory whose assumptions do not extend to that population. External validity therefore rests on clearly specified scope and boundary conditions.

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## 6.12 The narrative approach

The narrative protocol organizes explanation differently. It begins with a descriptive order that links events through time and examines how each development shapes what follows. It then constructs a configurative order by adjusting an interpretive framework to the historical facts through a process of abduction. The objective is to produce a convincing and plausible account of why events unfolded as they did. Narrative explanations are often richer and more holistic than nomological models because they emphasize combinations of causes and historically specific conjunctures. Their weakness, in Lake's view, is that the criteria for judging causal adequacy are more subjective. Narratives are evaluated in terms of verisimilitude and interpretive credibility rather than experimental internal validity.

Lake stresses that epistemology should not be confused with methodology. A nomological study can use historical case studies and process tracing, while a narrative analysis can employ large numbers of observations or statistical techniques. "Mixed methods" can improve research by testing theories in multiple ways, but mixing methods does not by itself eliminate the distinction between forms of explanation. Method concerns the techniques used to gather and analyze evidence; epistemology concerns what counts as a persuasive explanation.

## 6.13 Epistemological Sectarianism and Lake's Recommendations

The same pathologies that affect theory also affect epistemology. Scholars reify the nomological and narrative approaches, reward extreme positions, apply them selectively to problems where they are likely to succeed, and then claim universal superiority. These preferences have become politicized within the profession. Epistemological gatekeepers can influence hiring, resource allocation, publication, and access to professional networks, encouraging scholars to cluster with others who share the same standards of explanation. Lake sees no objective basis for declaring one epistemology universally superior. Scholars may simply find one form of explanation more intuitively satisfying than another, much as some people find beauty in mathematics and others in poetry.

Because neither epistemological tradition is likely to eliminate the other, Lake proposes three principles for coexistence. First, scholars should recognize the legitimacy of alternative forms of explanation and respect colleagues who use them. Treating one's own epistemological intuition as inherently superior is a form of intellectual hubris. Second, each approach should be judged on its own terms. Narrative work should be assessed for completeness, plausibility, competing interpretations, and possible distortion of historical evidence. Nomological work should be evaluated for logical deduction, valid operationalization, and sound research design. Third, scholars should accept that different approaches are likely to work better for different questions.

Lake illustrates this final point with substantive examples. Narrative approaches may be especially effective for slow, historically unique changes in global norms, such as transformations in attitudes toward slavery or human rights. Such processes unfold over long periods and are difficult to analyze while holding the social environment constant. By contrast, nomological approaches may be especially powerful when interactions are frequent and institutions are stable enough to generate repeated observations. Research on war and civil war, or on economic policymaking within established democratic institutions, can often benefit from this kind of analysis. The crucial question is therefore not "Which epistemology is best?" but "Which epistemology provides the greatest insight for this particular problem?"

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## 6.14 Conclusion

Lake concludes by returning to the social purpose of scholarship. Academic privilege is justified by the expectation that scholars will expand understanding. International studies fails in this responsibility when it devotes too much energy to theological wars among theoretical and epistemological camps. Progress comes from asking important questions about phenomena that remain poorly understood, choosing theories and methods appropriate to those questions, and evaluating evidence honestly. At the present stage of the discipline, no theoretical or epistemological approach merits hegemony. Diversity is necessary, but diversity should not take the form of isolated communities that speak mainly to themselves.

The essay's title is therefore deliberately provocative. "Isms" are "evil" not because realism, liberalism, constructivism, feminism, or other traditions are useless, but because scholars too often transform useful intellectual tools into identities and sects. Research traditions become harmful when they are treated as complete theories, insulated by selective evidence, and mobilized in struggles for disciplinary dominance. Lake's alternative is a more modest and problem-centered social science: partial theories with explicit limits, analytic eclecticism across traditions, a shared vocabulary of interests, interactions, and institutions, and mutual respect between nomological and narrative forms of explanation. The ultimate measure of success should be whether scholarship improves our understanding of world politics and contributes, where possible, to social progress.

## 7 Challenges to the Liberal Order: Summary

*David A. Lake, Lisa L. Martin, and Thomas Risse (2021)*

### 7.1 Introduction and Central Argument

In "Challenges to the Liberal Order: Reflections on International Organization," David A. Lake, Lisa L. Martin, and Thomas Risse assess the condition of the Liberal International Order (LIO) at a moment when it is under pressure from several directions at once. The authors emphasize that the postwar order has survived serious crises before, so its collapse should not be assumed. Yet the simultaneous interaction of internal political backlash, economic discontent, rising authoritarian powers, environmental and technological pressures, and attacks on multilateral institutions makes the contemporary challenge unusually broad. Their purpose is therefore both substantive and disciplinary: they ask what the LIO is, why it is being challenged, what may make it resilient, and what scholars of international relations failed to notice in earlier research.

The LIO has structured relations among the capitalist, democratic, and industrialized states since the late 1940s and has had wider global effects. It is associated with unprecedented cooperation among North America, Western Europe, and Japan, the emergence of a pluralistic security community, expansion of trade and capital mobility, high economic growth, the diffusion of democracy, and the development of an international human-rights regime. The authors do not treat these achievements as proof that the order has benefited everyone equally. Globalization created important distributional inequalities, and the LIO has performed poorly in areas such as climate change and the COVID-19 pandemic. Still, its record of cooperation and material improvement makes the intensity of current opposition an important puzzle.

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## 7.2 What Is the Liberal International Order?

The authors argue that common labels such as “American-led,” “open,” or “rule-based” do not fully define the LIO. The order is dynamic, has changed across time and issue areas, and coexists with regional orders such as the European Union. They therefore unpack the three words in the concept: order, international, and liberal.

## 7.3 Order

An order consists of patterned or structured relations. Social orders may arise spontaneously, but they may also be intentionally organized through rules, norms, and decision-making procedures. The LIO is clearly rule-governed and sustained by coordinated action by both state and nonstate actors. Nevertheless, being rule-based is not sufficient to make an order liberal: the Concert of Europe and the Westphalian order also relied on rules. Liberalism therefore requires additional substantive principles.

## 7.4 International and the Westphalian Order

The “international” component of the LIO has to be understood in relation to the Westphalian order. In the authors’ usage, Westphalia is not literally a system created in 1648 but a later order centered on sovereign nation-states, sovereign equality, recognition by other states, and noninterference in domestic affairs. The LIO and the Westphalian order partly overlap and have coevolved since 1945. They share principles such as sovereign equality, peaceful settlement of disputes, self-determination, and nonintervention. At the same time, the LIO goes beyond Westphalia through principles such as human rights and forms of legitimate collective intrusion into domestic affairs.

Figure 1 in the article captures this partial overlap. The liberal side includes democratic politics and economies, movement of goods and capital, human equality, rule of law, multilateralism, delegated or pooled authority, and collective security. The Westphalian side emphasizes ultimate state authority over territory and population. The common core includes sovereign equality, peaceful dispute settlement, self-determination, and nonintervention. This overlap is central because many contemporary conflicts arise precisely where liberal rules begin to constrain or penetrate sovereign authority.

## 7.5 The Liberal Components of the LIO

## 7.6 Political Liberalism

At its philosophical core, liberalism rests on universal human equality, freedom, and individual and collective self-determination. Political liberalism therefore implies the rule of law, representative government, political participation, and protection of individual rights. These commitments create tension with authoritarian regimes and, when international law reaches deeply into domestic political orders, with Westphalian sovereignty itself. Institutions such as the International Criminal Court and doctrines such as the Responsibility to Protect illustrate how the LIO can authorize constraints on domestic sovereignty in the name of universal rights.

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## 7.7 Economic Liberalism and Embedded Liberalism

Economic liberalism has appeared in different forms. A classical version favors market capitalism, free trade, international capital mobility, and equal treatment of foreign investment. In the contemporary period, critics often describe the expansion of this model as “hyperglobalization.” A second, historically important version is embedded liberalism. The postwar architects of the Bretton Woods system accepted the benefits of international openness while recognizing that markets could create severe domestic disruption. They therefore combined trade liberalization with domestic welfare states and, for decades, limits on capital-account mobility. Compensation for globalization’s losers was understood primarily as a domestic responsibility.

The distinction is important because economic liberalism does not automatically contradict Westphalian sovereignty, but the tension grows when international rules prescribe domestic institutions or policies. Neoliberal pressures for deregulation, privatization, independent central banks, or welfare-state retrenchment can be perceived as external constraints on democratic sovereignty. Migration intensifies the contradiction. The LIO broadly liberalized goods, services, and capital but never generally established free movement of labor outside the EU. Receiving states therefore confront a clash among economic efficiency, liberal rights, political inclusion, and national boundaries.

## 7.8 Liberal Internationalism

The institutional dimension of the LIO is based on principled multilateralism. Multilateralism means more than coordination among several states: it means coordination according to generalized rules that apply across cases rather than ad hoc bargaining based solely on particular interests. The Most Favored Nation principle in the GATT/WTO and collective security in the UN Charter exemplify this logic. Liberal internationalism also includes peaceful dispute resolution, the ambition to provide global public goods, security communities such as NATO, and multilateral arms-control and nonproliferation regimes.

Here too, tensions with Westphalia increase when authority is pooled or delegated to supranational bodies. Majority voting, dispute-settlement mechanisms, and international courts can constrain individual states. The deeper and more authoritative such institutions become, the more likely they are to provoke resistance from actors who want to restore national control.

## 7.9 Universalism and Selective Participation

The LIO contains a paradox. Because liberalism begins from universal equality, the order is in principle open to all states. Yet states can join important parts of the LIO without being liberal democracies. China, for example, has participated deeply in multilateral economic institutions while rejecting political liberalism at home. Illiberal states may join because of material gains, reputation, legitimacy, or the costs of remaining outside nearly universal institutions. Liberal states, for their part, have often welcomed such members in the expectation that participation will socialize them into more liberal behavior.

This produces a heterogeneous order. Some liberal rules have near-universal acceptance, while others are embraced selectively. Even liberal states differ in how much intrusion they accept: the United States has resisted institutions such as the International Criminal Court and, under President Trump, withdrew from the Paris Agreement before rejoining under President Biden. Conversely, some nonliberal states participate in intrusive human-rights arrangements. The LIO is therefore best understood as an evolving order whose components vary in reach rather than as a single uniform system imposed everywhere by the United States.

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## 7.10 Challenges from Within the Liberal Core

The most striking contemporary threats come not only from geopolitical rivals but also from the internal workings of liberalism itself. The authors identify several mechanisms through which the LIO generates opposition within its own core members.

First, economic liberalism creates winners and losers. Trade openness, technological change, global production chains, and the financial crisis of 2008–2010 have produced geographically concentrated losses and contributed to rising inequality. These effects can spread through local communities, affecting employment, welfare, identity, and political behavior. The result is a backlash against globalization that feeds nationalist and populist movements.

Second, political openness can be used against liberalism. Freedom of expression and the open architecture of the internet allow misinformation, foreign influence, and strategies of “truth subversion” to circulate widely. Autocratic governments can exploit these channels, while domestic populists can reject the Enlightenment conception of truth based on reason and evidence. Climate-change denial, conspiracy theories, and early denial of COVID-19 illustrate how liberal openness can create opportunities for actors hostile to liberal political norms.

Third, liberalism has often relied on partially illiberal institutional strategies. Free-trade policies and supranational governance were sometimes insulated from popular pressure in order to prevent protectionism and secure long-term cooperation. Over time, however, this technocratic insulation excluded some constituencies and created resentment. International institutions appeared less responsive to citizens, and opposition could be mobilized around demands to “take back control” or repatriate sovereignty.

Fourth, liberal universalism collides with national identity. The expansion of rights, multiculturalism, immigration, and transnational authority raises the political question of who belongs to the national community. Migration is particularly difficult because the LIO combines strong norms protecting refugees with persistent state control over borders and citizenship. These tensions have become central to contemporary electoral politics.

## 7.11 Nationalist Populism and Political Realignment

These pressures converge in movements combining nationalism, populism, and authoritarianism. Nationalism prioritizes the interests and identity of a particular state; populism pits a supposedly homogeneous “people” against elites and pluralist institutions; authoritarianism rejects liberal constraints such as independent courts, a free press, and fair electoral competition. The election of Donald Trump in 2016, Brexit, and the growth of authoritarian-populist parties across Europe exemplify the trend. Similar dynamics are visible outside the Western core in countries such as India, Brazil, and the Philippines.

The authors also note potential realignments in domestic political cleavages. In the United States, an urban–rural divide has become increasingly salient. In Europe, the traditional socioeconomic left–right divide is increasingly supplemented by a cleavage between liberal/cosmopolitan and nationalist/authoritarian positions. These changes matter because they make hostility to the LIO part of ordinary domestic electoral competition rather than an external or marginal phenomenon.

## 7.12 External Challengers

External pressures reinforce these internal tensions. Technological change has accelerated economic displacement beyond the capacity of existing welfare institutions to compensate. Climate change threatens the global environment while creating powerful distributional conflicts because firms and groups with carbon-intensive assets stand to lose from effective climate policy.

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China is the most important state challenge. Its extraordinary economic growth was enabled in part by participation in the open international economy, yet China remains authoritarian and strongly defends sovereignty and noninterference. It accepts many parts of economic liberalism and multilateralism while rejecting democracy, a free press, and intrusive human-rights norms. Whether China is a status quo power, a selective reformer, or a future builder of a more state-centered order remains unresolved. The authors emphasize that Chinese behavior varies by issue and that Western policy choices can influence the direction of this evolution.

Russia, Turkey, Iran, Saudi Arabia, and other states challenge different dimensions of the LIO. Russia especially favors a stricter Westphalian order, has violated post-Cold War norms through the annexation of Crimea and interference in other states, and has used cyber operations to disrupt democratic politics. Transnational Islamist movements challenge the liberal commitment to universal equality in still another way. The COVID-19 pandemic, although not an intentional actor, also tested whether states would cooperate through institutions or retreat into nationalism and unilateral border closures.

### **7.13 The Erosion of Multilateral Institutions**

Internal and external challenges converge most directly in attacks on multilateralism. Multilateral institutions have experienced crises before, including the collapse of the Bretton Woods monetary system and the US decision to invade Iraq without broad UN support. What appears different in the contemporary period is the breadth of skepticism and the willingness of major states to weaken institutions without a clear systemic necessity.

The WTO is a central example. Even before the recent crisis it struggled to negotiate large new trade agreements, but it still underpinned the world trading system through existing rules and its dispute-settlement mechanism. Under the Trump administration, the United States combined protectionist tariffs with a strategy of blocking appointments to the WTO Appellate Body, impairing enforcement. At the same time, the United States withdrew from or attacked several other multilateral commitments, including the Paris climate agreement, the Iran nuclear deal, the UN Human Rights Council, and arms-control arrangements. The Biden administration reversed some of these moves, but the episode demonstrated that US commitment to multilateralism cannot simply be assumed.

The refugee regime illustrates a broader erosion of multilateral commitments. The principle of nonrefoulement and the 1951 Refugee Convention created legal obligations toward asylum seekers, yet receiving states have increasingly adopted restrictive or deterrent policies. The COVID-19 pandemic intensified this tendency: many governments closed borders, pursued nationally oriented responses, and competed over research, medicines, and access to scarce medical supplies. International organizations such as the WHO and IMF responded, but often slowly, while the EU eventually mobilized a very large recovery package. The crisis therefore showed both the weakness and the continuing necessity of collective institutions.

### **7.14 Sources of Resilience**

Despite the severity of the challenges, the authors identify four reasons why the LIO may persist. First, the order has produced substantial benefits: reduced conflict among core members, economic growth, lower global poverty, and extensive international cooperation. These benefits give many governments and social actors a reason to preserve the basic architecture even while renegotiating specific rules.

Second, the LIO has generated vested interests. Firms have built global investments and supply chains that depend on open trade and predictable international rules. Although these interests

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have not always mobilized effectively against protectionism, they still have strong material incentives to resist deep fragmentation of the global economy.

The same interdependence that creates vulnerability can also reinforce support for openness. The US–China trade conflict and pandemic disruptions demonstrated how deeply production has been disaggregated across borders. Companies may struggle to organize politically, but the sunk costs embodied in global value chains make a complete retreat from international economic integration expensive. The authors also note that some unilateral US moves produced substantial international isolation, as happened when the Trump administration left the Paris Agreement and moved to sever ties with the WHO.

Third, the LIO is institutionalized in treaties, regimes, and international organizations. Such institutions are “sticky”: once created, they can outlast the circumstances that produced them and act as shock absorbers during crises. NATO’s persistence after the Cold War is a prominent example of this institutional continuity.

Fourth, the order has accumulated legitimacy. After decades of operation, many rules of multilateral cooperation have acquired a sense of normality and rightfulness. Actors may follow them not only because they calculate immediate benefits but also because compliance is seen as appropriate. This normative support can generate countermobilization when leaders openly attack the order.

Legitimacy matters because it changes the political baseline. Practices that once required active justification can become taken for granted as normal components of international life. When governments violate them, domestic and international audiences may react not simply because material interests are harmed but because the violation appears inappropriate. This accumulated normative capital does not guarantee survival, but it raises the political cost of dismantling established cooperation.

Resilience, however, does not imply that every component of the LIO will survive unchanged. The authors’ argument is more cautious: institutions, interests, and legitimacy create powerful forces of continuity, but those forces now confront challenges that are both more diverse and more mutually reinforcing than in many earlier crises.

## **7.15 Four Analytic Blind Spots in IR Scholarship**

The final major contribution of the article is a reflection on why international-relations scholarship did not better anticipate the present crisis. The authors identify four blind spots that should shape future research.

## **7.16 Orders Include by Excluding**

International orders operate like clubs. Membership provides benefits but also requires acceptance of rules created by existing insiders. Exclusion, stigma, and the threat of losing membership help enforce order, yet the same mechanisms can generate resentment. States that remain outside, or aspirants that believe the standards for full acceptance continually rise, may form oppositional coalitions. Thus, exclusion is not merely a defect at the margins of the LIO; it is partly constitutive of how the order functions and of why it produces challengers.

## **7.17 Orders Are Not Neutral**

The LIO embodies particular material and normative interests. Its rules privilege some actors, values, and policy models over others. Much institutionalist research emphasized how institutions



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facilitate cooperation and improve welfare, while constructivist research often treated widely shared norms as morally progressive. Both traditions sometimes underplayed distributional consequences and the fact that rules are written by particular actors for particular purposes. Cooperation can be Pareto-improving while still distributing gains unequally, and norms can be legitimate to insiders while appearing biased or stigmatizing to outsiders. The globalization backlash and debates over “Asian values” reveal these neglected conflicts.

## **7.18 Institutions Depend on Social Foundations**

Institutions are not autonomous objects floating above society. They survive because social groups invest political resources in creating and defending them. Institutional insulation may sometimes be necessary to protect long-term cooperation from short-term pressures, but excessive insulation can sever institutions from their social foundations. Trade and supranational governance illustrate this danger: institutions designed to secure liberal outcomes became less responsive to losers from openness, thereby helping generate the opposition that now threatens them. Robust institutions therefore require continuing political and normative support, not simply legal durability.

## **7.19 Domestic Politics Can Challenge the Order Itself**

IR scholarship has long studied domestic variables, but usually to explain foreign-policy outcomes such as war, trade, or cooperation. It paid much less attention to the possibility that parties, protest movements, territorial cleavages, and mass political realignments inside core states could attack the international order itself. The contemporary experience of Brexit, populist movements, urban–rural polarization, and clashes among social movements shows the need to integrate comparative-politics research on parties, elections, and contentious politics more directly into theories of international order.

## **7.20 The United States and the Future of the Order**

The article closes with an open question about American leadership. Earlier theories often treated US hegemony as central to the creation and maintenance of the postwar order, while later institutionalist work argued that international institutions could sustain cooperation even as American relative power declined. The authors complicate the debate by stressing that the LIO was never solely an American construction: Latin American states and other middle powers contributed significantly to the development of both Westphalian and liberal principles. This history suggests that declining US leadership does not automatically imply the collapse of the order.

Three broad futures remain possible. The LIO could survive because existing institutions and old and new stakeholders defend it. It could erode toward a more traditional Westphalian order centered on sovereignty and noninterference. Or it could be transformed into a hybrid order that preserves economic openness and principled multilateralism while altering commitments to democracy, human rights, and international legal authority. The authors do not choose among these outcomes. Their central conclusion is that the present crisis should be treated as an empirical and theoretical research agenda. Understanding the LIO requires attention not only to cooperation and institutions but also to exclusion, distribution, identity, domestic political conflict, and the social coalitions that sustain or undermine international order.

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## Part II

# Session 3

### Session 3, February 23: The strategic perspective

\*\*\* Bueno de Mesquita (2013)[Introduction]

- Bueno de Mesquita (2013)[Chapter 1]
- Bueno de Mesquita (2013)[Chapter 2]

## 8 Bueno de Mesquita, 2013 Introduction

### 8.0.1 Basic Principles

1. The actions that leaders take to influence events in the international arena are motivated by their personal welfare and, especially, by a desire to stay in office. Leaders' concerns for the national interest are subordinate to personal interests. If the two coincide, then so much the better; if they do not, leaders do what they believe is best for themselves even when doing so harms most citizens and, in that sense, the national interest.
2. International relations cannot be separated from domestic politics. Every foreign policy action is undertaken in the shadow of the domestic political consequences the action is expected to produce. Therefore, if a foreign policy is expected to achieve beneficial consequences for a nation in the long term but in the short term will result in the ouster of the leader, then that policy will not be pursued.
3. Relations between nations and between leaders are driven by strategic considerations. As such, foreign policy decisions are designed to influence international affairs and the leader's well-being. To be effective in this, foreign policies must be chosen with an eye toward the reaction they will create among friends and adversaries. The reaction expected from a policy choice is compared with the reaction anticipated from other policy options. Leaders pick the policy they believe will produce the best outcome for them, knowing that, at the same time, domestic and foreign rivals are choosing policies to enhance their own well-being.

### 8.0.2 Liberalism

Liberal theories emerged as a counterweight to the neorealist perspective. Unlike realist approaches, liberalism draws attention to the frequent and often long-standing occurrences of international cooperation. Indeed, a desire to explain such cooperation is its first point of departure from neorealism. Furthermore, for liberal theories, structural hierarchy, which implies the presence of an actor that can authoritatively enforce agreements between states (rather than anarchy, a system in which states must be able to help themselves because they cannot count on anyone else), is the central organizing principle of international politics. The presence of a hegemonic state (an overwhelmingly dominant power) helps enforce norms of conduct and maintain regimes. Norms are generally observed patterns of conduct.

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### 8.0.3 Constructivism

Constructivism, is a theoretical perspective that focuses on explaining how certain types objectives come into being or change. Constructivism began primarily as an attempt to theorize about the formation of identity, that is how we see ourselves.

Constructivism does not view decision makers as primarily strategic. Rather, leaders are thought initially to adopt a course of action for strategic reasons—to obtain legitimacy—but then to become caught up in socially accepted norms of conduct.

Unfortunately, much of the empirical research to evaluate this theory's conjectures is poorly designed to do so.

Thus, their research designs tend to unintentionally contain an antifalsification bias.

Recent efforts to evaluate constructivism in a manner more consistent with the scientific method tend not to find much support for constructivist hypotheses.

Constructivism leads to the expectation that preferences will converge among the members as they adopt shared norms and are subjected to pressures and persuasion. Nevertheless, König and Luetgert report that, "The results refute the claims of constructivists predicting that positions converge and increase the capacity to act due to common norms, rhetoric action or persuasion" (2005, 6).

### 8.0.4 A BRIEF HISTORY OF INTERNATIONAL RELATIONS THINKING

Wilson's idealism, the dominant approach to international affairs before World War II, painted a rosy picture of states cooperating with one another in promoting peace, democracy, and prosperity.

Today, realist ideas, in their turn, face significant challenges. These challenges reflect: (1) the insufficiency of realist theories to anticipate or explain the peaceful ending of the Cold War and the accompanying implosion of the Soviet Union and the unraveling of its Eastern European empire (Gaddis 1992); (2) the discovery that several of the most important realist propositions suffer from logical inconsistencies (Milner 1998; Powell 1994, 1999); (3) the discovery that key logically consistent realist propositions turn out to be falsified by the record of history; and (4) the growing evidence that the causes of and solutions to international conflict can be better understood, as urged by Russell and Wright, by looking within states (Bueno de Mesquita et al. 2003; Fearon 1994; Smith 1996).

The Treaty of Westphalia emphasized territoriality over personal loyalties as the foundation for international relations. It was primarily in this emphasis on the institutional importance of borders that the treaty broke with the feudal past.

The idea of territoriality has other significant implications. An important one concerns the central role that states play in international affairs. Because each state's territorial borders define a domain within which its rulers have sovereign authority over the use of force (Krasner 1999; Spruyt 1994), international law has come to view all states as legally equivalent entities. This, in turn, is a factor behind the realist concept of the state as a unitary actor. It is why international relations focus on states and not multinational corporations, ethnic groups, or other ways of dividing up the international pie.

His outlook embodies the idea that there should be no separation of powers, that the state's interests and the leader's interests are one and the same. In such a world, treating states as unitary actors (the king) makes perfectly good sense.

Central among these differences are the extent to which leaders are accountable to a small inner

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circle of supporters or to a broad constituency and the extent to which leaders insulate themselves from accountability to their core constituency.

**Iraq and the Realist View** At least in the years 2003-2007, American leaders who were concerned about advancing Iraq's reconstruction seem to have believed, in solid realist fashion, that American power was, by itself, enough to ensure that Iraq would follow the policy path prescribed by the United States.

Iraq's leaders would pay more attention to managing their relations with contending Iraqi factions such as those led by Muqtada al-Sadr (the anti-American cleric) and Grand Ayatollah Ali Sistani (the more moderate religious leader) than to implementing the policies promoted by the United States. Realist theory leaves little room for such a focus on domestic threats to political survival.

many foreign policy developments, from the collapse of the Soviet Union and the end of the cold war to the morass in Iraq, are at least as much the product of domestic politics as of international competition. To fix such problems, we have to think about the motivations and incentives of leaders and of rival politicians and about how we can alter their behavior based on responding to their motivations and incentives rather than worrying so much about the balance of power between states.

#### 8.0.5 Solving International Relation Puzzles

Each of these subjects, and many others, are explored in the chapters that follow. These issues are generally discussed in terms of four broad categories of problems: coordination, distribution, monitoring, and sanctioning. Coordination entails finding ways for states or leaders to act together in pursuit of common objectives. Distribution concerns the allocation of scarce goods among citizens, leaders, and states. Monitoring involves detecting situations in which one or another leader or state has cheated on an agreement. Sanctioning concerns punishing cases of cheating. These four generic issues are at the core of cooperation.

#### 8.0.6 Power, Preferences, and Perceptions: The Three Pillars of International Relations

International relations as a subject is primarily about the choices and actions that political leaders take in the name of their nation to influence how their state relates to other states.

In August 1991, for instance, hundreds of thousands of Russian citizens intent on deflating a coup in progress gathered in Moscow's Red Square. Those who gathered there believed that they could help shape the course of events. They acted on this perception by mobilizing the power they had in numbers to display their preference.

**Power:** Ultimately, power is about mobilizing resources to alter the behavior of others. Power is an instrument for promoting and achieving goals.

**Preferences:** Foreign policy goals and the ways nations interact with one another are reflections of the preferences, or desires, of key foreign policy leaders and those constituents whose support they require to stay in office. The preferences of constituents are important because if a leader's preferences are sufficiently inconsistent with the wants and desires of his or her core constituents, then the leader runs the risk of being overthrown. Such a risk emanates from two sources. First, opponents capable of jeopardizing a leader's authority may arise from within the state, as is true when there is a revolution, coup, or electoral defeat.

In addition, opponents may arise from outside the state.

**Perceptions:** Leaders may misjudge the amount of resources or degree of power they can

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mobilize on behalf of their nation or miscalculate the level of political support that will follow from their pursuit of articulated preferences.

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## 9 Bueno de Mesquita, 2013 Chapter 1, Evaluating Arguments about International Politics

Theories are important in helping us sort out which facts are essential in understanding international affairs.

Every theory should be susceptible to being falsified by evidence and should be evaluated in terms of its logical consistency.

In keeping with the first principle of wing walking, a theory should not be abandoned before there is substantial evidence in favor of an alternative explanation.

You might think that a review of the history of lots of past events and circumstances is the road to understanding.

Explanations, however, are not strings of facts. Explanation requires theory.

### 9.1 Constructing Theories

constructing theories  $\Rightarrow$  assumptions

1. Assumptions are the principal means by which theorists simplify reality.
2. Assumptions limit the domain of circumstances that the theory is capable of addressing
3. A good starting place to judge a theory's value is to evaluate whether its assumptions contradict one another—that is, whether there are internal inconsistencies.

**Judging Theories:** Perhaps the most influential international relations theorist of the post-World War II decades, Hans Morgenthau.

**Truth and Falsity in Assumptions:** So while true and false refer to internal consistency,, useful or trivial refers to its empirical value.

The value of one or another assumption is a practical matter; if an assumption adds to the theory's predictive ability more than it takes away, then it is useful.

**The First Principle of Wing Walking** If you are out on the wing of an airplane in flight, don't let go of what you are holding on to unless you have something better to hold on to.

**The Case Study Method and Testing Theories** When cases are selected because they are consistent with a particular claim, they are not a fair test of the accuracy of the claim.

**Selection Bias:** selection of cases was driven by ex post knowledge of the value on the dependent variable.

The principle of random case selection has been well established among statisticians for over a century.

Remember that theories are about relationships among variables, not about constants.

**Example:** Commonly, the researcher selects a case with a known cooperative outcome and then looks for the existence of an international regime or organization that can be said to have fostered the cooperative outcome. Perhaps the author is correct in the assessment of the role of the regime, but this does not at all tell us whether similar regimes also operated in settings that did not lead to cooperation between states.

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**A Standard for Comparing Theories** This means we choose one theory over another if it clearly outperforms the competing theory (Popper 1963; Laudan 1977; Lakatos 1978).

### **The Scientific Method**

1. Scientific analysis requires logical consistency
2. Competing arguments can be evaluated through experiments that control for confounding, alternative explanations.
3. Randomness ensures that the tests control for the possible effects of other factors.
4. Tests must also be replicable;

**When a Theory Is Wrong** A theory is more or less parsimonious depending on how many facts it explains compared with the number of assumptions it requires to make predictions. In general, the more events or facts a theory can explain with a limited set of assumptions, the greater the potential usefulness of the theory and the greater its parsimony.

**Scientific Theories Must Be Falsifiable** It is essential that a theory seeking the imprimatur of science be susceptible to possible falsification.

### **Practical use of Theories**

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## 10 Bueno de Mesquita, 2013 Chapter 2, The Strategic Perspective

The strategic perspective  $\Rightarrow$  1- foreign policy is part of normal domestic politics 2- any national leader faces a difficult problem in balancing the interests of constituents and the desires of foreign rivals.

Four basic categories of international problems arise: (1) coordination, (2) distribution, (3) monitoring, and (4) sanctioning. Each of these is molded internally by agency problems.

Rather than speaking of governments in categorical terms such as democracy, monarchy, and autocracy, we use two crucial domestic factors to differentiate them: (1) the size of the selectorate (those with a say in choosing leaders) and (2) the size of the winning coalition (those in the selectorate whose support is essential to keep a leader in office).

Polities that rely on a large winning coalition emphasize producing public goods over private rewards for coalition members. They produce greater prosperity, more efficient governance, and low rates of corruption; their leaders stay in office for a relatively short time.

Polities that rely on a small winning coalition and a large selectorate, such as autocracies with rigged elections, tend to produce high degrees of kleptocracy, poor public policies, and high levels of corruption and rent-seeking; their leaders last in office for a very long time.

States with large-winning-coalition systems are more likely to enjoy not only prosperity but also peace, especially with one another, while states with small-winning-coalition systems tend not only to be poor but also to experience lots of wars with other states, as well as undergoing revolutions, civil wars, and coups d'état.

States with large-winning-coalition systems differ from states with small-winning-coalition regimes in their use of foreign aid, military intervention, warfare, and a host of other critical choices in international affairs.

### 10.1 International Politics: Domestic Politics with a Twist

There is at least one critical difference between domestic and international politics. In the arena of purely domestic affairs, political leaders need not worry that their actions will prompt a foreign government to jeopardize their hold on power.

In domestic politics leaders select policies (including foreign policies) and actions designed to keep them in office.

In international affairs, leaders must worry that their foreign policies not only may mobilize domestic opposition capable of overthrowing them but also may irritate a foreign rival, sparking attack and possible defeat. That distinction is central to the principles of international politics (Putnam 1988).

#### 10.1.1 Example: The Afghan Taliban's Problem in 2001

Afghanistan's Taliban leaders drew important support from Osama bin Laden and others in Al Qaeda's terrorist network, and Al Qaeda had turned Afghanistan into their home base. For the Taliban to break with them would surely have aroused an active effort by Al Qaeda and its allies to depose the Afghan rulers and replace them with others more likely to cooperate. Yet the United States and its key allies were visibly banding together after September 11, 2001, threatening to overthrow the Taliban government unless it broke with bin Laden. The Taliban chose to gamble that the American threat was less dangerous than the risks associated with



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breaking with Al Qaeda.

### 10.1.2 Example: The Israeli Prime Minister's Problem

Without pro-settler policies, it is difficult for any Israeli prime minister to stay in office.

Given that Israel's proportional representation electoral system encourages small, fringe parties and given that the conservative Likud Party and the more centrist Kadima Party both rely on support from religious parties to muster a majority in the Knesset, we know that these parties cannot hold office if they alienate the pro-settlement religious party voters.

Almost certainly all parties to the dispute want a peaceful settlement more than they want war but they cannot agree on the contents of such a settlement (Fearon 1995).

### 10.1.3 Who and What to Study in International Affairs

1- Coordination entails finding ways for states or leaders to act together in pursuit of common objectives. Neither the Israelis nor the Palestinians want to collide; they would all like to coordinate on peace.

2- Distribution concerns the allocation of scarce goods among citizens, leaders, and states.

3- Monitoring involves putting into place the means to detect whether one or another leader or state has cheated on an agreement.

4- Sanctioning concerns punishing cases of cheating and is always susceptible to the parties deciding to renegotiate their agreement because punishing the cheater can be costly for the compliant signatory or signatories too.

International treaties provide a common means of addressing these problems and represent an important feature of international efforts at cooperation.

principal agent problem between the leaders who negotiate and the constituents.

We often don't have enough information to sort out whether our leaders are faithfully serving our interest.

Associated with the principal-agent problem, we as citizens may face another generic problem tied to monitoring and sanctioning our leaders (Aggiungo io, selection problems nel scegliere i leaders).

### 10.1.4 The Strategic Perspective

Lots of evidence has been compiled that shows international law and international organizations tend to be pretty ineffective when the stakes are high and national leaders are disinclined to abide by common norms of action.

### 10.1.5 Domestic Theories of International Affairs: A First Look

The actions of leaders are incentive compatible with their desire to stay in power and control revenue allocation.

James Fearon (1994), Alastair Smith (1998), and others suggest that democratic leaders are more likely than autocrats to carry out the foreign policy threats they make because of their domestic political **audience costs**.

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Schultz (1998, 2001) shows another feature that follows from having a domestic audience and thus audience costs: because of the risk of losing office following an unsuccessful foreign policy adventure, there is a **selection effect**.

→ **audience costs** ⇒ **selection effect**.

Democratic leaders, facing a legitimate and vocal opposition, are less likely to select risky foreign policies than are autocrats.

Democrats are much more likely to win the wars they start than are autocrats, not just because they are generally better at fighting wars but because they cannot afford to lose if they hope to get reelected.

**Domestic Theories of International Affairs: Example** Schultz's reasoning offers a compelling explanation for the appearance, and disappearance, of a bipartisan American foreign policy.

Typically, American foreign policy is thought of as nonpartisan and as driven by efforts to advance the national interest. Rarely, however, is there much effort to explain why partisanship should not be as important in foreign policy decisions as it is in the routine domestic choices of political leaders.

If the incumbent party and its leaders select a foreign policy that is unpopular or that is believed will be unsuccessful, then they can anticipate that the other party's leaders and candidates will see an opportunity to win votes by opposing the majority party's foreign policy.

## 10.2 Selectorate Theory

The selectorate theory represents one version of the strategic perspective.

In selectorate theory, leaders build a coalition of supporters among the selectorate. The selectorate (S) consists of those who have at least a nominal say in choosing leaders and are eligible to become members of a winning coalition. The winning coalition (W) is the subset of the selectorate without whose support an incumbent cannot be sustained in office.

**Leaders attempt to retain the loyalty of their supporters by giving them more benefits than any domestic political opponent can credibly promise to deliver.** Rewards come in two varieties:

(1) private goods:

Private goods are rewards that benefit only those who get them—that is, members of the leader's essential coalition of supporters.

Examples might include privileged access to government contracts, exploitation of a black market, or protection against prosecution.

(2) public goods.

Public goods are government policies and programs that all people benefit from whether they are in the leader's inner circle or not.

Examples of public goods include national defense, free speech and free assembly, public parks, equal protection under the law, and free access to education.

The selectorate theory's five rules of governance are as follows:

1. Depend on as few key people to keep you in power as possible.

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2. Draw that small group of essential coalition members from as large a pool of people as possible.
  3. Tax people as much as possible, subject to the constraints that they continue to work and pay taxes rather than take siestas, and that they are not made so miserable that they decide it is worthwhile to risk revolting rather than continue to live with the existing political system.
  4. Reward your essential backers just enough so they stick with you rather than shopping around for a new leader who might do more for them.
  5. Don't spend resources on benefiting the general population when those resources are needed to keep the loyalty of the members of your essential coalition.

When domestic institutions constrain a leader to require a broad base of support private rewards are an inefficient way to retain power (de Tocqueville 2000; Lake and Baum 2001; Bueno de Mesquita et al. 2003; Bueno de Mesquita and Smith 2011). Democratic leaders would have to spread these rewards across so many people that each would receive too little for the benefits to influence their loyalty to the incumbent.

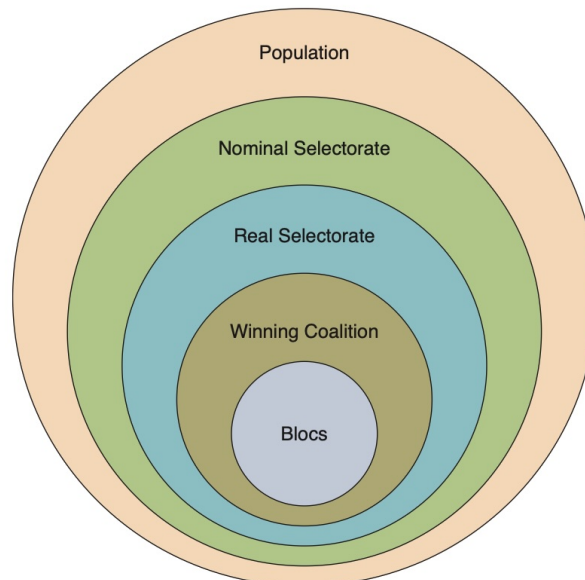
When political institutions compel a leader to depend on many supporters so that a bundle of public goods is the reward for retaining the incumbent, **the institutions of governance induce weak loyalty to the incumbent.**

Conversely, when a leader needs backing only from a few people to stay in power, the few are expected to be loyal both because they are well rewarded with private benefits and because they face a high risk of losing those privileges if a challenger topples the incumbent regime.

**FIGURE 2.2**

**Governance Institutions**

**Governance Dimensions: Nested Selectorate Institutions**



**Figura 5**

Historically, we have spoken of categorical types of regimes, like democracies or autocracies. In practice, no two governments are alike. All political systems have two institutional characteristics that describe how they retain and select their leaders.

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When  $W/S$  is small, as in a rigged election autocracy, then there is a **strong loyalty norm** that makes it easy for leaders to survive in power and exert great discretion over revenue as explained next.

**Examples: Egypt vs HCina and Syria vs Nigeria** For example, China and Egypt both had winning coalitions with a size that was close to 0 percent of the adult population, yet Egypt back then had a larger real selectorate than China relative to their adult populations. This means that both regimes, as we will see, were heavily oriented toward private goods but that leaders had more discretion over revenue in Egypt than in China. All else being equal, then, Egypt's then leader Hosni Mubarak had a better chance of remaining in power against an ordinary political challenge than did China's then incumbent president Hu Jintao.

Syria and Nigeria differ markedly. Nigeria has a smaller selectorate than Syria but depends on a much larger winning coalition. This means that the loyalty norm is stronger in Syria than in Nigeria. That makes the preparedness of the winning coalition's members to take extraordinary actions on behalf of the incumbent regime more robust in Syria than in Nigeria.

**Examples: Putin** Putin needed support from only half the members of parliament to get their legislative program through the Duma and, in a two-party race, each candidate needed only half the voters to support him to be elected, making the maximum minimal winning coalition in Russia 25 percent  $[0.5 \text{ (voters per seat)} \times 0.5 \text{ (number of seats)}]$ . With more than two parties (and there were seven parties contesting the 2011 Duma election), the actual minimal winning coalition was smaller.

### 10.3 Public and Private Goods: Who Gets Rewarded as $W$ and $S$ Change?

$W$  = Winning Coalition, it is the subset of the selectorate without whose support an incumbent cannot be sustained in office.

$R$  = Total revenues

$p$  = price of public goods

$g$  = mix of public goods

$z$  = each coalition member's private goods benefits

$$z = (R - p * g) / W$$

The odds of being in a successor coalition are the ratio  $W/S$ , which in this case is  $100/1,000,000$ , or  $1/10,000$ .

The expected value of the prospective defector's share of the private goods to be dispensed by the successor regime is only 1000.

$$\frac{\text{total revenues}}{\text{number of winning coalition}} * \text{probability of belonging to the coalition} =$$

$$\frac{R}{W} * \frac{W}{S} = \frac{1,000,000,000}{100} * \frac{100}{1,000,000} = 1000$$

The incumbent can keep the difference between the 10 million per supporter that could be distributed, and the something above 1,000 per supporter that needs to be distributed.

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It is easy to see that as long as the incumbent beats that expectation and provides public policies that are not much worse than those proposed by the challenger, the would-be defector can be kept happy and loyal.

### 10.3.1 Conclusions

1. **the greatest incumbency advantage in using private goods to satisfy constituents belongs to the leaders of political systems that have small winning coalitions and large selectorates.**
2. **Supporters in a large-coalition public-goods-oriented setting receive the benefits of public goods even if their leader is replaced by a challenger, such as after an election. This means that they can support a challenger with little consequence since they are getting few private gains in any event.**

### 10.3.2 Leader Survival

Autocracy and democracy are fundamentally different in their consequences even though all leaders are assumed to want the same thing (to keep their jobs and have discretion over as many resources as possible). Democratic politics in selectorate theory is a competition in competence to produce public goods; autocratic politics centers on the purchase of the loyalty of key supporters through bribery, corruption, and rent seeking.

### 10.3.3 Conclusion

The selectorate theory logically implies several basic principles of politics that are applied repeatedly throughout this book. The most important of these principles are as follows:

1. Regimes with large winning coalitions focus on effective policies, including foreign policies. When leaders' policies do poorly, they either switch them or pour more resources into trying to make them succeed.
2. Regimes with small winning coalitions tolerate failed domestic and foreign policies better than do regimes with large coalitions because in small-coalition settings loyalty to a leader depends more on receiving private rewards than public benefits. As a consequence, leaders mostly continue on their policy course even when their policies are failing. They do not change course as quickly as large-coalition leaders, and they do not put extra resources into trying to make the policies, including foreign security and trade policies, succeed under most circumstances.
3. The likelihood that a leader survives in office despite failed policies increases as  $W/S$  decreases (so that the polity becomes more autocratic) and decreases as  $W/S$  increases (so that the polity becomes more democratic).
4. As  $W/S$  increases, leaders must spend more revenue to maintain loyalty among their coalition members and, as a result, these leaders have proportionately fewer revenue sources at their discretionary use than do those who depend on a small coalition drawn from a large selectorate.
5. Corruption and kleptocracy (governing by theft) increase in prominence as  $W$  gets smaller, especially when  $S$  also gets larger.

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6. The foreign policies of small-coalition leaders are more heavily driven by the pursuit of opportunities for enrichment through territorial conquest, tribute, and the like rather than the pursuit of policy compliance from foreign rivals.
  7. The foreign policies of large-coalition leaders are more heavily driven by the pursuit of policy compliance by foreign governments than by the pursuit of enrichment.
  8. When leaders can change political arrangements, they prefer to decrease the size of their coalition and increase the size of the selectorate.
  9. When coalition members can change institutions (e.g., through coups), they always prefer to increase the ratio  $W/S$  and may, depending on circumstances, prefer to do so by increasing  $W$  more quickly than  $S$  or decreasing  $W$  more slowly than  $S$ .
  10. When people who are not in the coalition have the opportunity to change institutions of government (e.g., through revolution or civil war), they always prefer to increase  $W$  and to increase  $W/S$ .

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## Part III

# Session 4

### Session 4, March 2: Bargaining theory of war

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